

DEBUNKED — SIKHISM SERIES
PART 3 OF 13

The Eight Silent Gurus

From Guru Angad Dev Ji to Guru Tegh Bahadur Sahib Ji — what actually happened is deeper than the miracle.

Lovepreet Singh

An investigative debunk — 10 sakhis from the lives of the eight Gurus between Nanak and Gobind, with named sources and Gurbani citations.

The Eight Silent Gurus

Sikhism is usually introduced through two Gurus. Guru Nanak Dev Ji, who opened the path. Guru Gobind Singh Ji, who gave it the Khalsa. Thick books have been written on both lives, and rightly so.

Between them stand eight more.

One hundred and thirty-six years of unbroken succession runs through those eight men — from Guru Angad Dev Ji's installation in 1539 to Chandni Chowk in 1675. They built Goindval and Amritsar. They dug the sarovar and raised the Harmandir. They gathered, edited, authenticated and sealed the Adi Granth. They put a second sword on the belt and called it miri, and left the first one there and called it piri. One of them was executed in Mughal custody at Lahore in 1606. Another was beheaded in Chandni Chowk in 1675 for a community that was not even his own. In between, a seven-year-old carried water to the dying in a Delhi epidemic and caught what they had.

I call them silent because we say less about them, not because they said less.

We are Sikhs. These eight are the spine of the tradition, and the same miraculous plaster that was laid over Guru Nanak Dev Ji's udasis has been laid over their lives too. Part 2 of this series scraped that plaster off the founding figure. This part does the same work for the eight who followed, using the same six-step structure, the same named sources, the same refusal to either inflate or dismiss.

Ten sakhis are examined here. The invention of an alphabet. Twelve years of penance on one leg. An emperor sent to sit on the floor and eat. A city gifted as dowry. A Sufi's hand on a foundation brick. A smile on a hot iron plate. Fifty-two kings and a cloak with fifty-two tails. A rare herb that cured a prince. A touch that cured smallpox. A headless body that walked with its own head.

Some of these sakhis are broadly historical and have been decorated. Some are decorations with no history under them at all. A few are almost certainly nineteenth-century additions that have been retold so often we now assume they are ancient. In every case there is a real event underneath, and in every case I have found the real event to be the more demanding of the two. That has been the pattern of this whole series and it has not broken yet.

When I say Sai Mian Mir did not lay the foundation brick of the Harmandir Sahib, I am not saying the story is worthless. I am saying that the meaning of that story never depended on the event. It depended on us, and on what we decided the story was for. A tradition that can only hold its meaning by being factually true is a tradition standing on one leg.

Part 1 examined the claims other people make about us. Part 2 examined the sakhis we tell about Guru Nanak Dev Ji. Part 3 is about the eight who built quietly, in the long middle of our history, where the greatness is not in the miracle but in the labour.

— Lovepreet Singh

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Every chapter follows the same six-step structure: **The Claim** • **Where It Came From** • **What the Tradition Says** • **The Real History** • **The Debunk** • **The Honest Picture**.

truth is the highest of all; but higher still is truthful living

— STAND ON THE TRUTH, NOT ON THE SAKHI

Guru Angad Dev Ji Invented the Gurmukhi Script

THE CLAIM

Guru Angad Dev Ji created the Gurmukhi script from nothing. He designed a brand-new alphabet so that Sikhs would have a script of their own, free of Devanagari and free of Brahmin control, and gave Punjabi its written form for the first time.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

This is not a Hindutva claim or a colonial one. It is ours. The sentence "Guru Angad Dev Ji invented the Gurmukhi script" appears in Punjab school textbooks, in SGPC-published biographies, in almost every English-language introduction to Sikhism, and in the kathas delivered every year on his gurpurab. It gained its present force during the **Singh Sabha** period (1873 onward), when establishing Sikh distinctness was urgent work and a separately invented alphabet was excellent evidence for it. The motive was honourable. The word was wrong.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE TRADITION SAYS

Guru Angad Dev Ji (1504–1552, Guru from 1539) settled at Khadur Sahib. He taught children himself, prepared a primer of the letters for them, established schools, ran a wrestling arena for the young, collected and preserved the hymns of Guru Nanak Dev Ji, and composed sixty-two saloks of his own that stand in the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji today. The tradition holds that the letters he taught came to be called *Gurmukhi* — "from the mouth of the Guru."

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — THE SCRIPT FAMILY

Gurmukhi belongs to the Brahmi family. Its line runs Brahmi → Gupta → **Sharada** (Kashmir, c. eighth century CE) → the **Landa** and **Takri** scripts of the Punjab hills and bazaars. Landa (literally "clipped") was the shorthand of Punjabi traders and accountants — Mahajani, Sarrafi, Khojki and others. It was fast, and it was unreliable, because it carried almost no vowel notation. A trader reading his own ledger could fill in the vowels from context. A stranger reading a hymn could not.

The decisive evidence sits inside our own scripture. **Guru Nanak Dev Ji's *Patti Likhi*** — Raag Asa, **ang 432** of the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji — is an acrostic of thirty-five stanzas, one for each letter, composed by the first Guru, years before Guru Angad Dev Ji held the guruship. From roughly the ninth to the thirty-third stanza the sequence matches the order Gurmukhi uses today. An acrostic is only possible when the alphabet already exists *and* when the audience already knows its order well enough to feel the pattern. Guru Amar Das Ji later composed his own *Patti* on ang 434, and Bhagat Kabir Ji's *Bawan Akhri* uses the same device.

The earliest surviving Gurmukhi manuscripts are the **Goindval Pothis**, compiled around the 1570s under Guru Amar Das Ji, followed by the **Kartarpuri Bir** of 1604. Comparative palaeography — the letter-by-letter comparison of shapes — places Gurmukhi's characters alongside their Landa, Takri and Sharada cousins. Several are effectively identical.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

Invention means bringing into existence something that was not there. Standardization means fixing something that was there but varied. Everything we have points to the second.

- **The letters predate him.** They descend from Sharada through Landa, and their shapes show it.
- **Guru Nanak Dev Ji wrote an acrostic in them.** You cannot write an alphabet poem in an alphabet that has not been invented yet.

- **He never claimed it.** Not one of Guru Angad Dev Ji's sixty-two saloks mentions creating a script. **Bhai Gurdas Ji**, who praises him at length in *Var 1*, does not mention it either — and Bhai Gurdas Ji was not a man who left achievements out.
- **What he actually did is documented.** He fixed the order, settled the forms, and — the change that mattered most — gave the script full vowel notation, the *lagaan matra* that Landa lacked. He then taught it to children rather than to a priestly class.

That last point is not a technicality. A mis-vowelled shabad is a mis-read shabad. Scripture cannot be entrusted to a script that leaves the vowels to guesswork. The compilation of the Adi Granth in 1604 was possible because sixty-five years earlier someone had made the script exact.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Standardizing a script is not the lesser achievement. William Caxton did not invent the Latin alphabet; he fixed English spelling with a printing press, and no one thinks less of him for it. Guru Angad Dev Ji took a merchant's shorthand and turned it into a vehicle capable of carrying revelation — then handed it to farmers' children at a time when Sanskrit was gate-kept by caste and Persian was the language of the court.

Every Punjabi who reads Punjabi today reads because of that decision. Every Punjabi newspaper, every school primer, every ang of the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji sits on it. This is an enormous thing to have done, and it is entirely true. It does not need the word "invented" holding it up.

Guru Amar Das Ji Stood on One Leg for Twelve Years

THE CLAIM

Before he became Guru, Bhai Amar Das performed twelve years of severe penance at Khadur — standing on one leg, going without sleep, punishing the body — and it was this tapasya that earned him the guruship.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The one-leg detail is not in the mainstream Sikh account. It is a **Puranic motif** imported into a Sikh biography. Standing on one leg for years is the signature image of penance in Hindu narrative literature — Dhruv, Bhagirath, Ravana and dozens of lesser figures all do it. When Sikh lives were retold in nineteenth and twentieth-century popular literature, and again in the children's books and colour-plate calendars of the last fifty years, the motif attached itself to the twelve years Guru Amar Das Ji genuinely spent at Khadur. It also does useful work for the absorption argument examined in Part 1: a Guru who performs tapasya is legible as a Hindu ascetic.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE TRADITION SAYS

The mainstream Sikh account is specific and quite different. Amar Das of Basarke was a Vaishnav who made some twenty pilgrimages to Haridwar and came home each time unsatisfied. In his sixties he heard **Bibi Amro** — Guru Angad Dev Ji's daughter, married into his extended family — reciting Guru Nanak Dev Ji's bani at dawn. He asked to be taken to her father. From roughly 1540 to 1552 he served at Khadur: carrying water from the Beas, about five kilometres away, before dawn for Guru Angad Dev Ji's bath, walking the return journey backwards so as never to turn his back on the Guru. He also washed dishes, ground grain, carried bricks and fetched fuel. He was installed as the third Guru in 1552, at seventy-three.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — GURU AMAR DAS JI AT A GLANCE

Born 1479 at Basarke, near Amritsar. Guru from 1552 to 1574. Founded Goindval on the Beas and built the baoli there with its eighty-four steps. Created the **manji** system — twenty-two preaching seats, several headed by women — which is the first administrative structure in Sikh history. Made langar a precondition of audience. Spoke against sati and against purdah. Composed the *Anand Sahib* in Raag Ramkali. His hymns in the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji are commonly counted at 907, the third-largest body in the Granth.

Nothing in the contemporary or near-contemporary record — not Bhai Gurdas Ji's vars, not the Goindval Pothis, not the early janamsakhi material — describes penance of any kind. What they describe is *seva*: sustained physical labour performed for others. The line most often quoted from this period is Guru Angad Dev Ji's public defence of him when a village woman mocked him as "the homeless old man who carries water" — *he is not homeless; he is the shelter of the shelterless.*

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

Gurbani does not merely fail to endorse tapasya. It refuses it, by name, in the opening prayer of the tradition. Guru Nanak Dev Ji, *Japji Sahib*, pauri 21, **ang 4**:

"tirath tap dayaa dat daan / je ko paavai til kaa maan" — "Pilgrimage, austerity, compassion and charity: whatever honour these bring is worth no more than a sesame seed."

Guru Amar Das Ji's own compositions carry the same rejection of ritual self-punishment. A man who spent his life arguing that God is not reached by austerity did not reach God by austerity.

Then there is the body. Standing on one leg for twelve years is not a difficult feat; it is a physiological impossibility. Sustained unilateral weight-bearing on that scale would destroy the joint within months, and no such case exists in the medical literature or in any reliable historical record anywhere.

The deepest problem is that the substitution reverses the meaning. **Tapasya is suffering directed at yourself. Seva is labour directed at someone else.** They are opposites. The sakhi takes the second and quietly swaps in the first, and in doing so it deletes the entire point.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

A sixty-one-year-old man walked five kilometres before dawn, every day, for twelve years, carrying water on his head so that another man could bathe. He walked home backwards out of respect. He washed dishes. He ground flour. He did this in old age, with no promise of anything, and at seventy-three he was handed the guruship by a Guru who had watched him do it.

That is the teaching, and it is a hard one: greatness in this tradition is available through ordinary unglamorous work, done late, done for others, done without withdrawing from the world. Replace it with a man balanced on one leg and you have not made the story bigger. You have returned him to precisely the tradition he walked out of, twenty pilgrimages later, when he finally heard something worth staying for.

Akbar Was Made to Stand in the Langar Queue and Was Rebuked

THE CLAIM

Emperor Akbar came to Goindval to meet Guru Amar Das Ji and was refused an audience until he had sat on the floor in the pangat and eaten langar with the poorest people present. In the stronger versions, the Guru also rebuked him to his face for his pride.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The episode is Sikh in origin and reaches English readers chiefly through **Max Arthur Macauliffe's** *The Sikh Religion* (Oxford, 1909), which drew on Sikh informants and earlier Punjabi accounts. It travels because it is perfect: one scene, one emperor, one floor, and the whole doctrine of equality delivered without a word of theology. It is told at every school assembly and in most gurdwara kathas. The rebuke element is the part that has grown — the earliest tellings have Akbar complying willingly and cheerfully, not being scolded.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE TRADITION SAYS

In 1567, travelling towards Lahore, Akbar halts at Goindval. He asks to see the Guru. He is told the rule: *pehle pangat, pichhe sangat* — first the row, then the congregation. He removes his shoes, sits on the floor in a line with everyone else, and eats coarse langar food. Afterwards, impressed, he offers a jagir — the revenue of several villages — to endow the kitchen. Guru Amar Das Ji declines, saying the langar must live on the small offerings of ordinary people and nothing else.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

Here the evidence needs sorting into two piles, and they are not the same size.

What the Mughal record documents: Abu'l Fazl's *Akbarnama* records Akbar at **Goindval in 1598**, on his return from Lahore, where he met **Guru Arjan Dev Ji** — two Gurus later — and remitted the year's land revenue for the region because the harvest had failed. That meeting is in the imperial chronicle, dated, with a policy consequence attached.

What the Mughal record does not document: the 1567 visit to Guru Amar Das Ji. It appears in neither the *Akbarnama* nor the *Ain-i-Akbari*, both of which are unusually detailed about Akbar's movements and about his meetings with religious figures — Abu'l Fazl records the Jain teachers, the Zoroastrians, and the Jesuit mission of Rodolfo Acquaviva by name. The Goindval langar episode rests entirely on Sikh sources of the seventeenth to nineteenth centuries.

DEFINE — SULH-I-KUL

"Peace with all" — Akbar's stated policy of religious accommodation, formalised through the Ibadat Khana debates that began in 1575 and the abolition of the jizya tax in 1564. A ruler with this record stopping to meet a well-known Punjabi teacher is entirely in character. The policy makes the visit plausible; it does not make it documented.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

Two claims are bundled here and they deserve different verdicts.

The langar rule is solid. That Guru Amar Das Ji required everyone — every rank, every caste, every visitor — to eat in the pangat before the sangat is attested across the sources and is visible in the institution itself, which has never had a second queue. This is not in doubt.

The specific scene is not. No contemporary record, Mughal or Sikh, places Akbar on that floor in 1567. And the rebuke version carries the fingerprints of improvement in transmission: the visitor changes between

retellings, the degree of humiliation rises with each generation, and the Guru's words get sharper the later the source. An anecdote that gets better every time it is told is an anecdote being edited.

There is also a problem with the punchline. Akbar eating on the floor with commoners was not the extraordinary humbling the sakhi needs it to be — he did this kind of thing habitually, and made a public virtue of it. The story quietly requires an emperor who would never stoop, and Akbar was not that emperor.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

The rule never needed the emperor. What makes langar radical is not that a king once obeyed it. It is that the rule applied identically to everyone, every day, whether or not a king was in the room — in a society organised around who may not eat with whom, in a century when that organisation was not questioned.

And the better fact is the one we almost never tell. Guru Amar Das Ji refused state revenue for the kitchen. An institution funded by the sangat cannot be leveraged by the state, cannot be withdrawn as punishment, and cannot be used as a lever in a negotiation. That is a structural decision about independence taken four centuries before anyone had the vocabulary for it — and it is worth considerably more than the image of a humbled emperor sitting on a floor.

The Land of Amritsar Was Akbar's Dowry Gift

THE CLAIM

The land on which Amritsar stands was a gift from Emperor Akbar to Bibi Bhani, daughter of Guru Amar Das Ji, on her marriage to Bhai Jetha — later Guru Ram Das Ji. The Harmandir Sahib therefore stands on ground donated by a Mughal emperor.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

This one is ours as well, at least originally. Nineteenth-century Sikh accounts record an imperial grant, and the detail was flattering: it showed the Guru's household honoured by the throne. It has since hardened into examination-paper fact — "which Mughal emperor donated 500 bighas of land to Bibi Bhani?" is a stock question in Indian competitive-exam guides. It also does quiet political work in both directions today, appearing in composite-culture framings where the site's origin becomes a story about Mughal generosity, and in arguments that Sikh institutions were dependent on imperial patronage from the start.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE TRADITION SAYS

Bibi Bhani married Bhai Jetha of Lahore, an orphan who sold boiled grams and who would become the fourth Guru. Akbar, in the version told alongside the langar episode of Chapter 3, is so impressed by Guru Amar Das Ji that he settles a jagir on the Guru's daughter — the revenue of several villages, or five hundred bighas of land, depending on the telling. On that land Guru Ram Das Ji later excavated the sarovar, and the settlement that grew around it was called Ramdaspur, then Amritsar.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — THE COMPETING SIKH ACCOUNT

A second version, equally traditional, says the land was **purchased** — bought from the zamindars of the neighbouring village of **Tung** for **700 rupees**. Some accounts place the purchase in Guru Amar Das Ji's time, some in Guru Ram Das Ji's. Excavation of the sarovar is generally dated from 1577. Note that this is not a Sikh account against an outside account. It is two Sikh accounts against each other.

The chronology is the problem. Bibi Bhani's marriage is conventionally dated to about **1553–1554**. Akbar acceded in **February 1556**, at thirteen, and did not govern in his own right until the regency of Bairam Khan ended in **1560**. A wedding gift given in 1553 by a man who became emperor in 1556 and ruled from 1560 is not a difficult claim to assess.

The second problem is paper. The Mughal revenue administration was a documentation machine: *madad-i-maash* grants, jagir assignments and imperial farmans generated records, and large numbers of them survive across northern India. No sanad, farman or deed for this grant has ever been produced. Historians of Amritsar have concluded that in the absence of an authentic deed, Akbar's donation of this land cannot be established.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

- **The dates do not permit it.** If the grant was a wedding gift, Akbar was not yet ruling. Moving the grant later to fix this breaks the "dowry" framing that is the whole claim.
- **The document does not exist.** In an empire that recorded grants meticulously, this absence carries weight.
- **The rival account is more specific.** Named sellers (the zamindars of Tung), a named price (700 rupees), a named transaction. Vagueness is a property of invented history; specificity is expensive to fake.
- **We know what a real Mughal concession to the Gurus looks like in the record.** Chapter 3's 1598 revenue remission is in the *Akbarnama*: dated, chronicled, with an administrative consequence. The Amritsar grant has none of these features.

None of this touches the sanctity of the place. It touches the story we tell about ourselves, and that story turns out to be better without the gift.

If the land was bought, Amritsar was paid for by the sangat — small contributions, daswandh, the ordinary money of ordinary people. That is the same mechanism Guru Amar Das Ji protected when he refused imperial revenue for the langar, and the same one Guru Arjan Dev Ji later formalised. Three Gurus in a row holding one policy: build with your own money, and owe the state nothing. The dowry story quietly cancels that policy and replaces it with patronage.

This is not a point against Akbar. His documented act — waiving a year's land revenue for a famine-struck district in 1598 — is real, generous, and worth remembering accurately. We do not need to invent a second gift from him. We need to stop forgetting the first one.

Sai Mian Mir Laid the Foundation of the Harmandir Sahib

THE CLAIM

In 1588, Guru Arjan Dev Ji invited the Sufi saint Sai Mian Mir of Lahore to Amritsar and asked him to lay the foundation brick of the Harmandir Sahib — a deliberate act of interfaith respect, placing a Muslim's hand on the first stone of the Sikh world's holiest building.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

This is the most loved story in this book, and I do not enjoy writing this chapter. It is repeated by SGPC guides, printed in tourism literature, quoted by politicians of every party, and taught to children as the founding gesture of Sikh pluralism.

It is also traceable, almost to the year. **Dr Madanjit Kaur**, in *The Golden Temple: Past and Present* (Guru Nanak Dev University, 1983), followed the trail. The first Sikh writer to name Mian Mir as the layer of the brick is **Giani Gian Singh** — and only in the *third* edition of his *Panth Prakash*, published at Lahore. In the first edition (Delhi) and the second (Amritsar), he does not say who laid the first brick at all. In the third he says Mian Mir did, cites no source, and gives no explanation for the change. Among Persian works the story surfaces first in **Bute Shah's** *Tawarikh-i-Punjab* (1848).

Between 1588 and the late nineteenth century — roughly three hundred years, during which Sikhs wrote a great deal of history — not one Sikh writer records it.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE TRADITION SAYS

Mian Mir (1550–1635), the Qadiri Sufi of Lahore, is summoned by the Guru and lays the brick. A mason, watching, thinks it has gone in crooked and quietly resets it. The Guru sees this and says that because the brick was disturbed, the shrine will one day be pulled down and rebuilt.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — THE HARMANDIR CHRONOLOGY

Sarovar excavation begun under Guru Ram Das Ji from about 1577. Construction of the shrine begun by Guru Arjan Dev Ji in 1588 and completed around 1601. The Adi Granth, compiled 1604, installed inside with Baba Buddha Ji as the first Granthi. Four doors, one to each direction. Built below the level of the surrounding ground, so that the worshipper descends to enter — the inverse of a temple on a plinth.

The contemporary and near-contemporary sources are silent on Mian Mir. **Bhai Gurdas Ji** — who lived through the construction, scribed the Adi Granth, and wrote at length about Guru Arjan Dev Ji's works — does not mention him. Nor does *Sri Gur Sobha* (1711), nor the *Bansavalinama* (1769), nor the Gurbilas literature. Madanjit Kaur's conclusion from the earliest tradition is that **Guru Arjan Dev Ji laid the foundation himself**.

The silence runs on the other side too. Mian Mir was a major figure with a substantial Persian hagiography, including *Sakinat-ul-Auliya* (1642), a whole book devoted to him and his circle by **Dara Shikoh**, his own disciple. That literature records no such event. A Sufi master's biographers do not normally omit the day he founded another religion's central shrine.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

What makes this case unusual is that we can watch the story enter the record. It is absent from the first edition of a book, absent from the second, and present in the third, sourceless. That is not a tradition being transmitted. That is a tradition being added to.

The crooked-brick prophecy is the second tell. It exists to explain the destruction of the Harmandir Sahib by Afghan forces in the eighteenth century — the demolitions of 1757 and 1762. A prophecy that predicts an event which had already happened when the prophecy was first written down is doing retrospective work. It also dates the composition: after 1762, not in 1588.

Three centuries of silence, a sourceless late insertion, a back-dated prophecy, and nothing from the Sufi side. On any standard we would apply to someone else's claim, this does not stand.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Here is what hurts, and what helps: **the building already says it.**

Guru Arjan Dev Ji gave the Harmandir Sahib four doors, one facing each direction, so that it could not be entered from a single privileged side, and so that all four varnas had a way in. He set it below ground level, so that every person approaching it walks downward — the opposite of every temple architecture in the subcontinent, which raises the sanctum above the worshipper. Inside it he installed a scripture containing the hymns of Muslim and Hindu bhagats of low caste alongside those of the Gurus, which no other tradition on earth had done.

The interfaith statement is in the stone, the level, the doors and the book. We borrowed an anecdote to make an argument we were already standing inside. And Mian Mir does not need it either — the real friendship between Sufi and Sikh in seventeenth-century Punjab is documented well enough without a brick that nobody saw him lay.

Guru Arjan Dev Ji Sat Smiling Silently on the Hot Plate

THE CLAIM

Guru Arjan Dev Ji was tortured for five days at Lahore — seated on a red-hot iron plate while burning sand was poured over his body — and throughout it he sat serene and silent, without a sound of pain, reciting "tera kia meetha lage."

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The martyrdom is beyond dispute. The tableau is a later composition.

The earliest appearance of the red-hot pan and burning-sand imagery in connection with the Guru is in an apocryphal salok appended to the epilogue of the **Banno recension** of the Adi Granth, prepared in **1642**. **Professor Sahib Singh**'s textual analysis attributed the Banno apocrypha to the **Hindalis** — a schismatic group that followed a rival claimant, opposed Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji, and had aligned itself with the Mughal administration at Lahore. **Pashaura Singh** ("Understanding the Martyrdom of Guru Arjan," *Journal of Punjab Studies* 12:1) reads the passage as a possible oblique attack: how could a servant of God have been treated so, and if he was, what does that say about him? The imagery is fixed for later Sikh writing by **Kesar Singh Chhibbar's Bansavalinama** (1769), and becomes standard in the nineteenth century.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE TRADITION SAYS

Five days of torture in the summer of 1606. The hot plate, the burning sand, the cauldron of boiling water. Mian Mir arrives and offers to destroy the empire; the Guru forbids it. On the last day he asks to bathe in the Ravi, walks into the river, and does not come out. Throughout, the same line: *tera kia meetha lage* — "what You do is sweet to me."

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

Four independent sources survive from within four decades of the event. They agree the Guru was killed in Mughal custody. None of them describes a hot plate.

- **Jahangir, *Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri*** (the emperor's own memoirs). He writes that too many Hindus and Muslims had been drawn to "this shop of falsehood," that the Guru had blessed the rebel prince Khusrav, and that he ordered the Guru's property confiscated and the man himself executed — *siyasat o yasa*. This is the executioner's written confession.
- **Bhai Gurdas Ji, *Var 24, pauri 23*** — the only contemporary Sikh account. It treats the death as a hero's death. It does not describe the method.
- **Father Jerome Xavier**, letter in Portuguese from Lahore to the Provincial at Goa, **25 September 1606**, three months after the event, printed by Fernão Guerreiro. He records the arrest after the prince's flight, a fine of a hundred thousand crusados, a wealthy surety who then stripped the Guru's household — furniture, and the clothes of his wife and children — to recover it, then "beaten with slippers," food withheld, and death from the accumulated ill-usage.
- ***Dabistan-i-Mazahib*** (1640s): the Guru was tied and kept in the open in the desert around Lahore, and died "owing to the strong sun, summer heat and the injuries inflicted by the collectors."

DEFINE — SIYASAT O YASA

Yasa is the Mongol legal code of Chingiz Khan; *siyasat* is political punishment. In Mughal usage the pair meant capital punishment inflicted with torture and confiscation. It is worth setting beside one line from the same memoir: Shaikh Nizam Thanasari, a Muslim cleric, met and encouraged the same rebel prince — and Jahangir exiled him to Mecca with travel expenses. Same offence. Different religion. Different sentence.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

That the Guru was tortured is not in question — it is explicit in the sentence itself and in the Dabistan's "injuries inflicted by the collectors." What is not supported is the specific scene. The nearest source in time and place, written in Lahore that same season, gives beating and starvation. The Persian account gives exposure, heat and injury. The iron plate enters the record thirty-six years later, in a text prepared by a hostile sect, and hardens over the following century.

The recited line needs the same care. *Tera kia meetha lage* is Guru Arjan Dev Ji's own composition — Raag Asa, **ang 394** of the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji. It was written before, not improvised on a plate. Attributing it to that moment is devotional framing, and it is beautiful framing, but it is not a transcript. No one was taking dictation in a Mughal custody chamber.

The last problem is the one we should mind most. Later tradition moved the blame onto **Chandu Shah**, a Hindu official cast as the surety who tortured the Guru to recover his money — and Xavier's letter shows exactly how that reading became available. But Jahangir's memoir names the decision as his own. A version in which a private Hindu enemy is responsible lets an empire off the hook for a judicial execution it recorded itself.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Very few martyrdoms in world history are confirmed in the handwriting of the ruler who ordered them. This one is. We do not need the plate.

What actually happened is this: a state executed a religious teacher because his influence had grown across both religious communities and because he had blessed the wrong prince; it applied a foreign penal code to do it; it exiled a Muslim cleric to Mecca for the identical offence; and it confiscated everything the man owned. The Guru died in that custody in the Lahore summer of 1606 — observed on Jeth sudi 4, dated in various accounts to 30 May or 16 June.

His composure under it is the theological centre of the event, and nothing in the historical record contradicts it. But the composure is not a demonstration that a body can be immune to iron. It is a demonstration that a man can be held in the will of God while an empire kills him — which is harder, and truer, and is the thing his sons and grandsons actually inherited.

Bandi Chhor — Exactly Fifty-Two Kings Were Freed

THE CLAIM

Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji refused to leave Gwalior Fort unless the fifty-two imprisoned Hindu rajas were released with him. Jahangir agreed that only those who could hold on to the Guru's cloak might walk out, so the Guru had a cloak made with fifty-two tassels. All fifty-two were freed. Sikhs mark the day as Bandi Chhor Divas.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The imprisonment is historical. The number and the cloak are not from the same century as the imprisonment.

Dabistan-i-Mazahib (1640s) records Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji's detention at Gwalior. The fifty-two rajas and the tasselled cloak appear in the *Gurbilas Patshahi Chhevin* — a text whose dating is disputed, with serious scholars placing it in the **mid-nineteenth century** — and then in **Bhai Santokh Singh's *Suraj Prakash*** (1843) and **Giani Gian Singh's *Twarikh Guru Khalsa*** (late nineteenth century). The name *Bandi Chhor Divas* as a distinct Sikh festival is largely a **twentieth-century** consolidation, promoted during and after the Singh Sabha and Akali reform period, when giving a Sikh name to a day Sikhs already observed was a live political need.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE TRADITION SAYS

Jahangir imprisons the young sixth Guru at Gwalior — in some accounts over the unpaid fine levied on Guru Arjan Dev Ji, in others over the fortification of Amritsar and the raising of an armed force. Sai Mian Mir and Wazir Khan intercede. The release order comes. The Guru refuses to leave alone. The condition of the cloak is set, the cloak is made, and fifty-two detained rulers walk out holding it. He returns to Amritsar on Diwali, and the city is lit for him.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — WHAT IS ACTUALLY FIXED

Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji (1595–1644), Guru from 1606 at eleven, wore two swords — *miri* and *piri* — and built the Akal Takht facing the Harmandir Sahib. He was detained at Gwalior Fort, the empire's principal state prison for political detainees, including Mughal princes. Beyond that, the sources disagree substantially. The Sikh tradition dates the imprisonment to about 1611–1612; the *Dabistan* suggests roughly 1617–1619. Its length is given as forty days in some accounts, two years in others, and twelve years in a few. That spread is itself evidence of how thin the underlying record is.

Jahangir's *Tuzuk* — a memoir in which he freely records ordering the execution of this Guru's father — says nothing about detaining or releasing the son. And there is no imperial record anywhere of fifty-two detained rulers being released together, which would have been a significant political event.

The Diwali connection also predates the story. **Guru Amar Das Ji** had already instructed Sikhs to gather before the Guru at fixed points in the year, Diwali among them, which is why there was a large sangat at Amritsar on that day in the first place. **Bhai Gurdas Ji** uses the festival as an image in *Var 19* — "on the night of Diwali the lamps are lit" — writing in the sixth Guru's own lifetime, without attaching it to any release.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

- **The precision is the tell.** An exact count paired with a garment engineered to match that count is the architecture of a folk tale. Fifty-two recurs across North Indian narrative as a conventional "complete set" number, in the way forty and seven do elsewhere.

- **No contemporary source gives any number.** Not the *Dabistan*, not Bhai Gurdas Ji, not the Mughal chronicles. The number arrives with the nineteenth-century texts.
- **No list exists.** If fifty-two ruling houses had a raja freed by the Sikh Guru, we would expect several of those houses to have remembered it in their own chronicles and genealogies. No princely family has ever identified an ancestor among the fifty-two, and no accepted list of the names has ever been produced.
- **The festival link is later.** Sikhs were gathering at Amritsar on Diwali before the imprisonment, on Guru Amar Das Ji's instruction.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Strip the tassels off and what remains is the part that was always doing the work: **a man refused freedom that was offered to him alone.**

Whether the detainees numbered fifty-two or twelve or five, the principle does not move a millimetre. Liberation that stops at yourself is not liberation; it is a private arrangement with power. That is the doctrine, and it is entirely consistent with everything else this Guru did — the second sword, the Akal Takht built to face the Harmandir Sahib, the insistence that spiritual authority must answer temporal power rather than retreat from it.

Bandi Chhor, in Sikh usage, is a name for God: the one who releases the bound. Applying it to a man who would not walk out of a prison alone is not decoration. It is the highest compliment the tradition has. It does not need a cloak with fifty-two tails to hold it up.

Guru Har Rai Sahib Ji Cured Dara Shikoh With a Rare Herb

THE CLAIM

Aurangzeb poisoned his brother Dara Shikoh with a powdered tiger's whisker. The physicians found only one cure: two ounces of chebulic myrobalan and a clove weighing one masha. Neither could be found anywhere in the empire. They existed only in Guru Har Rai Sahib Ji's herbal storehouse at Kiratpur, and the Guru gave them freely, saving the prince's life.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

Sikh tradition, reaching wide circulation through **Macauliffe** and the twentieth-century devotional literature that followed him. It is a well-built story, because it is fastened at both ends to things that are true: Guru Har Rai Sahib Ji genuinely ran a dispensary at Kiratpur, and Dara Shikoh genuinely came to him for help. It also performs a useful explanatory job — it accounts for why Aurangzeb, once victorious, took an interest in the Guru's household.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE TRADITION SAYS

The prince is dying. The court physicians name two ingredients. Agents search the bazaars of the empire and find neither. The prime minister remembers the Guru at Kiratpur, who keeps the finest collection of medicinal herbs in India. The Guru hands them over without conditions and without being asked twice. Dara recovers.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — GURU HAR RAI SAHIB JI

1630–1661. Seventh Guru from 1644, grandson of Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji. Based at Kiratpur in the Shivalik foothills. Maintained a standing force of 2,200 mounted men and never fought a battle with it. Ran a herbal dispensary at Kiratpur that treated whoever arrived. In 1661 he sent his elder son **Ram Rai** to Aurangzeb's court, and disowned him when Ram Rai altered a line of Guru Nanak Dev Ji's bani — *mitti musalman ki* — to avoid offending the emperor. He never saw his son again, and passed the guruship instead to his five-year-old younger son, Har Krishan.

Documented: Dara Shikoh's defeat at Samugarh in May 1658 and his flight through the Punjab; the seventh Guru's assistance to him, recorded in Sikh sources and referred to in later Persian material; and Aurangzeb's summons of Ram Rai to Delhi in 1661, which is best explained by exactly that association.

Not documented: the poisoning and the cure. Dara Shikoh is among the best-recorded figures of the seventeenth century — the *Padshahnama*, the travel accounts of François Bernier and Niccolao Manucci, his own substantial writings, and the records of his trial. None of them records a poisoning by Aurangzeb followed by a miraculous recovery. Aurangzeb's actual disposal of his brother required no poison at all: capture in 1659, a trial for apostasy, and public execution in August of that year, all fully chronicled.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

The story fails on the pharmacy counter.

Chebulic myrobalan (*Terminalia chebula*; harad, haritaki) is not rare. It is one of the most widely used drugs in the subcontinent, the first of the three fruits in triphala, stocked by every apothecary and most kitchens in seventeenth-century India. **Cloves** were among the highest-volume commodities in the Indian Ocean spice trade, and the Mughal court was the wealthiest purchaser of spices in the world. The claim requires the imperial household, with unlimited money and the entire trade network of an empire, to be unable to obtain harad and a clove.

The specification is what does the trick. "A clove weighing one masha" — about a gram, an unusually large one — converts a bazaar commodity into a rarity by adding a requirement. This is a standard mechanism in miracle stories: take a common object, attach a precise and arbitrary condition, and the ordinary becomes unobtainable. The tiger's whisker is a folk-poison belief of the region rather than a pharmacological fact, and appears as a narrative device rather than a documented cause of illness.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Here is what actually happened, and it costs the Guru far more than the herb did.

A Sikh Guru ran a free clinic in the foothills and treated whoever walked in, including the losing side of a Mughal civil war. When the fugitive heir came through the Punjab, he helped him. Then the other brother won.

Aurangzeb summoned the Guru's household to account for it, and the Guru sent his elder son. That son, standing in front of an emperor, changed one word of Guru Nanak Dev Ji's bani to make it palatable — and his father cut him off permanently, handed the guruship to a five-year-old, and died without seeing him again.

That is the story: a man who gave medicine to whoever needed it, and who would not give up a single line of scripture to keep his own son. Nothing in it needs a poisoned prince.

Guru Har Krishan Sahib Ji Cured Smallpox by Touch

THE CLAIM

During the Delhi epidemic of 1664, the seven-year-old eighth Guru cured the sick by his touch and by his glance. Thousands who were dying of smallpox and cholera recovered because he laid a hand on them. The water he gave from the well at Jaisinghpura carried the cure, and carries it still.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

Devotional literature, gurpurab katha, and the enormous body of children's material produced in the last century. There is also a live modern layer: water from the sarovar at Gurdwara Bangla Sahib is widely described as curative, and pilgrims carry it home in bottles for the sick. The story is generally told alongside the Panjokhara episode, in which the young Guru is challenged to expound the Gita and has an unlettered water-carrier do it instead — a second miracle claim from the same short tenure.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE TRADITION SAYS

Guru Har Krishan Sahib Ji is summoned to Delhi through Raja Jai Singh, in connection with Ram Rai's rival claim, and stays at the raja's bungalow at Jaisinghpura — the site of Gurdwara Bangla Sahib. The city is in the grip of smallpox and cholera. He refuses to withdraw, serves the sick himself, draws water from the well for them, and heals by touch. He then contracts smallpox, and dies on **30 March 1664**, aged seven years and eight months, having named his successor only as "Baba Bakala."

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — WHAT SMALLPOX WAS IN 1664

Variola major killed roughly three in ten of those it infected and left most survivors scarred. There was no treatment anywhere in the world. Edward Jenner's vaccine is 1796; variolation was practised in parts of India and China earlier, but was neither available nor applicable during an outbreak in progress. Cholera, the other disease in Delhi that season, kills through dehydration and can be survived in a large proportion of cases if the patient is given clean water and kept hydrated.

The uncontested facts are these. There was an epidemic in Delhi in 1663–64. The Guru was in the city, at Jai Singh's residence. He did not leave. He served the sick, and water from that well was distributed. He caught the disease and died of it at seven. Before dying he pointed to Bakala, which is how the Sikhs found Guru Tegh Bahadur Sahib Ji.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

The claim contains its own refutation, and it is a gentle one. **A touch that cures smallpox cannot fail on the person doing the touching.** The Guru died of the disease he is said to have cured in thousands of others. Either the power existed and was withheld from himself for a reason no source offers, or it was not that kind of power at all.

The second problem is arithmetic. In any epidemic most infected people recover — roughly seven in ten with smallpox, and a large share of cholera cases where fluids are available. Anyone who spends weeks among hundreds of sick people is necessarily surrounded by hundreds who get better. Attribution follows presence. This is not cynicism about the Guru; it is a description of how healing claims are generated everywhere, in every tradition, including ones we do not belong to and judge easily.

Third, the Sikh position on miracle-working is not neutral. Guru Nanak Dev Ji's refusal of the siddhis in *Sidh Gosht*, examined in Part 2 of this series, is not a one-off. The Gurus consistently declined to make supernatural power the evidence of spiritual authority, precisely because it makes authority contingent on performance.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Now look at what he actually did, in the light of what we now know about cholera.

He gave the sick **clean water**, in an epidemic, in a crowded city, and he stayed with them. Clean water and fluid replacement are, to this day, the primary treatment for cholera — oral rehydration is one of the highest-impact medical interventions of the twentieth century. Food, shelter, attendance and clean water were, in 1664, not the poor substitute for a miracle. They were the entire body of effective medicine then available, and he supplied all four.

The sakhi asks us to believe in a healer who unaccountably failed to heal himself. The history offers a seven-year-old who walked into a plague city that adults were fleeing, would not leave it, did the only useful thing anyone could do, and paid for it with his life within weeks. He has no compositions in the Granth. He built no institutions. He held the guruship for under three years and did not reach eight years of age. What he had was one decision, taken at seven, about whether to stay.

That is the version worth telling a child, because a child can copy it.

Guru Tegh Bahadur Sahib Ji's Headless Body Carried Its Own Head

THE CLAIM

After the beheading at Chandni Chowk, the Guru's headless body rose to its feet, picked up its own severed head, and walked away through the crowd — in some tellings all the way towards Anandpur — before the Mughal soldiers could seize either.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

This is not the mainstream Sikh account. It is a **jhujhar** motif — the headless warrior who fights or walks on after decapitation — which is one of the most widespread hero-figures in North Indian folk religion, with hero-stones and shrines across Rajasthan, Haryana and Punjab. The motif attaches easily to any celebrated martyr, and it has attached to this one mainly through forwarded messages, devotional video content and some popular children's literature of recent decades. It also appears in retellings that recast Guru Tegh Bahadur Sahib Ji inside a Hindu miracle idiom, which is the absorption move examined in Part 1 arriving by a different door.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE TRADITION SAYS

The Sikh account has no walking body in it. It has two men and an enormous amount of risk. **Bhai Jaita** — later Bhai Jiwan Singh — took the severed head and carried it more than three hundred kilometres to Anandpur Sahib, where the nine-year-old Gobind Rai received it, and where the words *Rangretta Guru ka beta* are traditionally spoken. **Bhai Lakhi Shah Vanjara**, a transport contractor with carts and a reason to be on the road, took the body concealed in a load, brought it to his house at Raisina, and cremated it by burning his own house down so that the fire would not be questioned. Gurdwara Rakab Ganj stands on that spot.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — DELHI, NOVEMBER 1675

Guru Tegh Bahadur Sahib Ji, born Amritsar 1621, ninth Guru from 1665, founder of Anandpur. Approached by a delegation of Kashmiri Pandits led by Kirpa Ram of Mattan, seeking help against forced conversion. He went to Delhi. He was arrested with his companions and held at the Kotwali. **Bhai Mati Das** was sawn in two, **Bhai Dayala** boiled, and **Bhai Sati Das** wrapped in cotton and burned, in front of him, before his own public beheading at Chandni Chowk. The date is given as 11 November in the Nanakshahi calendar and 24 November in the older reckoning; the difference is calendrical, not factual.

The earliest account of the martyrdom comes from the person closest to it. The *Bachittar Natak*, attributed to **Guru Gobind Singh Ji** — his son, then nine years old — records it directly:

"saadhan het itee jin karee / sees deeyaa par see na uchree" — "For the sake of the holy he did this much: he gave his head, but never a groan."

"theekar for dilees sir prabh pur keeyaa payaan / teg bahaadar see kriaa karee na kinhoon aan" — "Breaking the earthen vessel of his body on the head of the ruler of Delhi, he departed for the abode of God. None other has ever performed a deed like Tegh Bahadur's."

The *Bansavalinama Dasan Patshahian Ka* (Kesar Singh Chhibbar, 1769) and the later Gurbilas literature carry the account forward. The Mughal record confirms the arrest, the detention at the Kotwali and the public execution in Delhi in November 1675.

- **The nearest witness is the son, and he describes no such thing.** Guru Gobind Singh Ji's account is precise, unsparing and proud, and states plainly that his father *gave* his head. A headless body walking through a Delhi crowd is not a detail a nine-year-old omits from his own father's martyrdom, and not a detail any later Sikh writer would have left out either.
- **The motif is regional, not specific.** The jhujhar appears attached to dozens of local martyrs across northern India. A story that fits many people equally well is usually about none of them in particular.
- **It erases the two bravest acts in the episode.** If the body walked itself out, Bhai Jaita did not need to carry a head three hundred kilometres past Mughal patrols, and Bhai Lakhi Shah did not need to burn his own house down to cremate a body. The miracle version deletes the human courage that makes the event Sikh in the first place.
- **The body cannot do it.** Decapitation ends coordinated movement immediately. This needs one sentence and no more.

One caution on sources, offered in the same spirit as the rest of this book: the authorship of parts of the Dasam Granth is genuinely disputed among Sikh scholars, and this series will deal with that dispute properly in a later part. The *Bachittar Natak's* account of the martyrdom is nonetheless the earliest we possess, and it is the account the Panth has read as the son's own for three centuries.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

The meaning of this martyrdom rests entirely on a single fact: **he did not have to be there.**

He was not a Kashmiri Pandit. He did not share their theology — the whole of Part 1 of this series is an argument about how far Sikhi stands from it, on the janneu, on caste, on ritual, on the nature of God. The Pandits were asking him to defend a religious practice that his own tradition had deliberately set aside.

He went anyway, and lost his head in a public square for their right to keep a thread he himself would not wear.

I do not know of another martyrdom in world history quite like it — a religious leader executed not for his own faith but for someone else's right to theirs. A corpse that walks adds nothing to that. It cannot. His son said it once, in a single line, and there has been nothing to add since: *he gave his head, but never a groan.*

What Part 3 Tried to Do

Ten sakhis, eight Gurus, one hundred and thirty-six years. Read together, they fall into three groups.

Some are **true events that have been decorated**. Guru Angad Dev Ji did transform a script — we simply used the wrong verb. Guru Amar Das Ji did serve for twelve years — we replaced labour with penance. Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji did refuse a private release — we added a number and a cloak. Guru Arjan Dev Ji was tortured to death in Mughal custody — we furnished the room.

Some are **additions with no event under them at all**. The foundation brick at Amritsar. The walking body at Chandni Chowk. The clove that could not be found in an empire built on the spice trade.

And some are **borrowed shapes** — motifs from the storytelling grammar of the wider region, pressed onto Sikh lives because they were the available forms. The ascetic on one leg. The headless jhujhar. The saint whose touch cures.

What strikes me, having done the work, is the direction of the loss. In every single chapter, the decoration made the Guru *smaller*. A man who invents an alphabet is less impressive than a man who takes a merchant's shorthand, adds the vowels, and hands literacy to farmers' children. A saint who cures by touch is less impressive than a seven-year-old who stays in a plague city and dies there. A body that walks is less impressive than Bhai Jaita walking three hundred kilometres with a head. Every time we reached for the supernatural, we put down something better.

There is a reason for that pattern, and it is not accidental. This tradition was built by people who explicitly refused to make miracles the proof of authority. When we decorate their lives with miracles, we are not merely adding untrue details. We are contradicting the thing they were arguing for.

None of this is an argument for reading these lives coldly. I do not think the sakhis should be discarded, and I do not think the people who tell them are foolish. A tradition needs its stories, and stories carry meaning in shapes that facts cannot. But a story told *as a story* and a story told *as history* are two different objects, and the second one can be taken from us by anyone who bothers to check. The first cannot.

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What's Next

Part 4 turns to the last of the ten — **Guru Gobind Singh Ji and the Khalsa: Sakhi and History**. Vaisakhi 1699 and what the sources actually say about the five who stood up. The arithmetic of the battles, and where our numbers come from. Chamkaur and the forty. The blue horse and the white hawk. Sarbloh, the Five Ks, and the invented sciences attached to them. And the question of what the Dasam Granth is, which this part has already touched and cannot keep postponing.

The same six-step structure. The same named sources. The same refusal to inflate or to dismiss.

— *End of Part 3* —